

Member Connect: A Member Referral Program

A proposal for a member-to-member referral system that helps chamber members send each other business, with lightweight recognition and a leaderboard built on top of the existing membership app.

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The Opportunity

Today, members support each other's businesses informally — at mixers, ribbon cuttings, and through word of mouth — but there's no structured way for a member to send a referral to another member, or for the chamber to see how much value members are already creating for each other.

Business networking organizations like BNI and LeTip have built entire membership value propositions around exactly this: giving members a structured, trackable way to pass business to one another. Many of your members likely already belong to (or have heard of) these groups. Bringing a well-designed version of this into the chamber app turns an invisible, informal benefit into a visible, differentiating reason to renew membership.

Why this is a good fit for this app specifically

The app already has a member directory, a working notification system (email + push), and a badge/recognition pattern from the existing Business of the Month program. This program builds on that foundation rather than introducing new infrastructure.

What we learned from comparable organizations

Organization	Model	Key takeaway for us
BNI	One member per industry per chapter; weekly meetings; tracks referrals, visitors, one-to-ones, and dollar value of closed business	Public visibility (leaderboards, scorecards) drives participation more than the points themselves
LeTip International	Similar structure to BNI, lighter-weight, tracks "tips" given	Simple volume-based recognition can work without heavy dollar-value tracking
Alignable	Open network (not one-per-category), public recommendations, activity feed	Closer structural fit for an open chamber where many members share a category
Most chambers today	No formal referral system — informal networking only	A well-built version of this is a genuine differentiator, not table stakes to match

The single most consistent lesson across all of these models: referral programs succeed or fail based on whether the person who gave a referral ever finds out what happened to it. "Closing the loop" is the design priority behind this proposal.

How It Works: The Core Loop

Rather than copying BNI's exclusive, one-per-industry chapter model — which doesn't fit a chamber where many members share a category — Member Connect is built around a simple four-step loop available to every member, every day, inside the app they already use.

1. Give A member finds another member in the existing directory and submits a referral: lead name, contact info, and a short note.	2. Receive & Acknowledge The receiving member is notified immediately and can see the referral in a "My Referrals" inbox.	3. Close the Loop The recipient updates a simple status (Contacted → In Discussion → Closed) so the referrer always knows the outcome.	4. Recognize The referral shows up chamber-wide (referrer and recipient only, never the lead), and a closed-won outcome can carry a public thank-you plus points, badges, and leaderboard credit.
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Feature Set

Give & track referrals (core)

- **Refer a Member** — submit a referral directly from any member's profile in the existing directory
- **My Referrals inbox** — one place to see everything given and received
- **Status pipeline** — Submitted → Contacted → In Discussion → Closed-Won / Closed-Lost / Not a Fit
- **Automatic notifications** — email and in-app alerts when a referral is received or its status changes

Public recognition & trust

- **Referral activity feed** — shows chamber-wide, by default, that a referral took place between two members (who referred whom)
- **Lead privacy, always** — the referred lead's identity, contact details, and any dollar value of closed business are never shown publicly, only to the referrer and recipient
- **Testimonials** — a short public thank-you a member can post about a referral partner

Recognition & leaderboard

- **Points & Connector tiers** — Bronze / Silver / Gold / Platinum, weighted toward closed business rather than raw volume
- **Leaderboard** — monthly and all-time views of top connectors
- **Connector of the Month** — a spotlight slot for the app and/or newsletter, mirroring the existing Business of the Month program

Admin & moderation

- Chamber-wide view of all referrals, statuses, and top connectors
- Ability to hide inappropriate entries or correct a stuck status
- Built-in guardrails: rate limits and de-duplication to discourage spammy referrals

Optional add-ons (not included in the estimate below)

Mobile push notification polish beyond what already exists, and automation that creates a record in the chamber's CRM when a referral closes. These are worth revisiting once the core program is live and member interest is validated. Dollar-value tracking of closed business was considered and intentionally excluded — that stays private between the two member businesses involved.

Phased Roadmap

The program is broken into seven phases. Each phase ships something usable on its own, so the chamber can see and react to the program before the next phase begins.

Phase	What you get
1. Foundation	The data model and backend API that everything else is built on
2. Core Referral Experience	"Refer a Member" flow from the directory, plus the "My Referrals" inbox with status tracking — the program is usable end-to-end after this phase
3. Notifications	Email and in-app alerts on new referrals and status changes
4. Admin Tools	Chamber-wide reporting and moderation controls — included in the first release rather than deferred
5. Public Recognition	Chamber-wide activity feed (referrer/recipient only, lead identity always private) and public thank-you testimonials
6. Leaderboard	Points, Connector tiers/badges, and the monthly/all-time leaderboard
7. Testing, Feedback & Revision	A structured test pass across all phases, a round of chamber staff/member feedback, and revisions to address what's found

Implementation Estimate

The table below estimates the hands-on-keyboard implementation time for each phase — writing the code and getting it working in this codebase, priced at \$75/hour. Figures shown are the minimum of each phase's estimated range, for planning purposes. It does **not** include code review, staging/production deployment, or App Store/Play Store review cycles, which should be scoped and budgeted separately.

Phase	Implementation effort	Estimated cost
1. Foundation	2 hours	\$150.00
2. Core Referral Experience	2 hours	\$150.00
3. Notifications	1 hour	\$75
4. Admin Tools	1 hour	\$75.00
5. Public Recognition	2 hours	\$150
6. Leaderboard	1.5 hours	\$112.50
7. Testing, Feedback & Revision	3 hours	\$225
Total (all 7 phases)	~12.5 hours	~\$937.50

Notifications (Phase 3) are inexpensive because this codebase already has working email and push-notification infrastructure in place — this phase reuses it rather than building new plumbing.

Turning effort hours into a project timeline

Raw implementation hours are only part of the calendar timeline. Add time for chamber staff review and feedback between phases, and any App Store/Play Store release cycles for mobile. A realistic phased delivery schedule with review checkpoints would run over several weeks rather than a single sitting, even though hands-on-keyboard time is well under a work-week.

Next Steps

1. Approve the full seven-phase program scope described above.
2. Run a short gut-check with a few members on whether points/leaderboards are motivating before committing to Phase 6 (Leaderboard).
3. Approve the phased roadmap and schedule QA/testing and release windows around it.